

*Cavia aperea*

Brazilian guinea pig



Location N.W. to E. South America

Length 8¼ – 15½ in (21.5 – 39 cm)  
Tail None  
Weight 18 – 29 oz (500 – 790 g)  
Social unit Group  
Status Least concern



A close relative and perhaps ancestor of the domestic (pet) guinea pig (*Cavia porcellus*), this is one of the smallest cavylike rodents. It has a large head, blunt snout, tail-less body, and short legs, with 4-toed front feet and 3-toed rear feet. The long, coarse fur is dark gray-brown to black. It eats leaves, grasses, seeds, flowers, and bark. Guinea pigs live as close neighbors in shrubby grassland, with communal feeding runways but separate nests.



*Hydrochoerus hydrochaeris*

Capybara



Location N. and E. South America

Length 3½ – 4½ ft (1.1 – 1.3 m)  
Tail Vestigial  
Weight 77 – 145 lb (35 – 65 kg)  
Social unit Variable  
Status Least concern



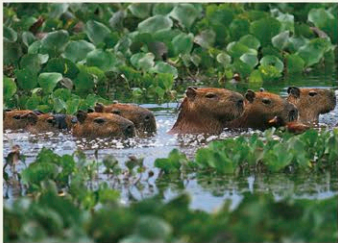
The world's heaviest rodent, the capybara has partially webbed toes, and its nostrils, eyes, and ears are set on top of its head, so that it can smell, see, and hear when

**STOUT SWIMMER**  
The capybara is heavy bodied, with short but sturdy limbs, hooflike claws, and almost no tail.



swimming. It is an excellent swimmer and diver in rivers, lakes, and swamps. It forms various groupings, including male–female pairs, families with young, and larger, mixed herds dominated by one male who mates with all females in his group. They roam a home range, marked with scent, and chase away intruders. After a gestation period of 120–150 days, 1–7 offspring (usually 5) are born fully furred and can run, swim, and dive within hours of birth. The capybara's numerous predators include humans, who value the meat and hide.

DAILY ROUTINE



Capybaras rest in the morning, wallow during the midday heat, feed on water plants, buds, and soft tree bark in the evening, rest again around midnight, and resume feeding toward dawn. They move on to find fresh grazing as necessary and may raid farm crops, which makes them pests in some areas.

*Dolichotis patagonum*

Patagonian mara

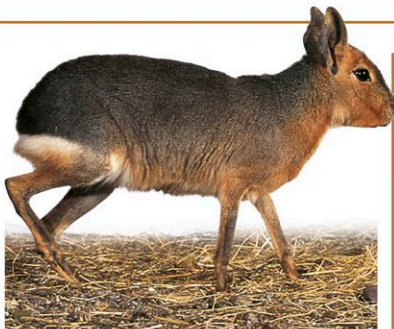


Location S. South America

Length 23½ – 32 in (60 – 80 cm)  
Tail 1 – 1½ in (2.5 – 4 cm)  
Weight 15 – 20 lb (7 – 9 kg)  
Social unit Pair  
Status Near threatened



The Patagonian mara is a large, long-legged rodent that resembles a small deer in looks and behavior. It has a white, collarlike neck patch and



whitish fringe to the short tail. The muzzle is long; the eyes and ears large. The Patagonian mara runs and jumps well, and is mainly a grazer on grass and low shrubs. Male–female pairs stay together for life, digging a large burrow for their 1–3 offspring.

*Dasyprocta azarae*

Azara's agouti



Location E. South America

Length 17 – 22¼ in (43 – 57.5 cm)  
Tail ¾ – 1½ in (1 – 3.5 cm)  
Weight 5½ – 6½ lb (2.4 – 3.2 kg)  
Social unit Variable  
Status Data deficient



This large, social, diurnal species has prominent ears, short legs, and a tiny tail. Its fur is speckled pale to mid-brown, perhaps tinged yellowish



around the underside. The distinctive feet have 5 toes on the front feet, but 3 on the hind feet. Azara's agouti eats a variety of seeds, fruit, and other plant material, and barks when alarmed. People hunt it for meat across much of its range.

*Cuniculus paca*

Lowland paca



Location S. Mexico to E. South America

Length 20 – 29 in (50 – 74 cm)  
Tail ½ – 1½ in (1.5 – 3.5 cm)  
Weight 11 – 31 lb (5 – 14 kg)  
Social unit Individual  
Status Least concern



Lowland pacas live alone, apart from the mother and single young, which she suckles for 6 weeks. This expert swimmer has a big head, squared-off muzzle, robust body, short, sturdy legs, and tiny tail. The upper body is brown, red, or gray with 4 pale “dotted-line” stripes along each side; the underparts are white or buff. The lowland paca rests in a burrow or hollow tree by day and emerges to eat fruit, leaves, buds, and flowers at night.



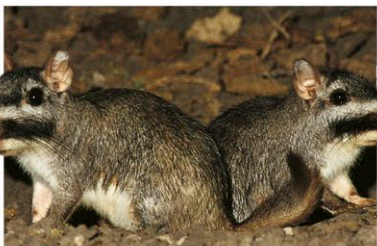
*Lagostomus maximus*

Argentina plains viscacha



Location C. and S. South America

Length 15½ – 24¼ in (39.5 – 62 cm)  
Tail 5¼ – 8 in (13.5 – 20.5 cm)  
Weight 16 – 19 lb (7.5 – 8.8 kg)  
Social unit Group  
Status Least concern



The largest member of the chinchilla family, the plains viscacha lives in noisy colonies of 20–50. It digs tunnel systems extending more than 980 ft (300 m). At night, it eats grasses, seeds, and roots, and collects sticks, stones, and bones to pile at tunnel entrances. The face is black and white striped, the back is gray-brown fading to white underneath, and the tail is brown-tipped with black. The male is twice as heavy as the female.